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CST301: For the love of Food

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Section :02

Midterm Script

A Cosmopolitan Plate on a Student Budget: Calamari, Care, and Hidden Labour in Banani

After paying a bill, most people forget their food at a restaurant. Mine did not. It was just a date, at the time. In retrospect, I noted that it had the questions of trust, labour, class and globalization, something I had all but forgotten to consider as I chewed my food. The reason for my visit to Rustic Eatery was to cool off after a hot and tiring day. This was just any old meal, but we were presented with choices of trust, negotiation, care, and self presentation. My girlfriend was in a craving for seafood.She didn't know if it would smell or be of poor quality in Dhaka restaurants. I told her because I knew it was a very good place, had been dining there for almost five years, and was familiar with its address on Banani, the way staff spoke to me, and their reputation. I don't like eating fish as it has bones and strong smell, but she likes seafood. I would be ordering fried calamari and agreeing to it, without raising any eyebrows about the preference, was a huge step for me to make. She offered to pay, I tried to think of something that she truly would enjoy. We had one shared plate and talked about getting a second plate. Appadurai's (1981) idea of gastro-politics gave me a vocabulary for something I had sensed but never articulated. Those small exchanges were never just about food. Food preferences, needs, or obligations are communicated through food choice, as is recognition, relationships. I then had a change of perspective in the course lecture, as it made me think of something I had assumed as a given before.The comfort and care might be personal but they are made possible by a broader institutional setting. The sharing of the calamari brought us closer together. Research also shows that eating together can strengthen personal connections (Garcia-Rada et al., 2019). Yet I should not romanticize the experience. Our comfort did not depend only on our relationship.It also relied on finances, transportation, the restaurant's location and a cool space. These resources are not equally available to everyone.

Who really counseled me about food? My girlfriend wanted seafood the most and offered to pay. But I had made the choice of restaurant, told her it was safe, asked the waiter questions, and helped her order the food. The restaurant also had a lot of decision making power. The menu gave the dish its name, the cashier recorded our order, and the kitchen calculated how long it would take to prepare. The chef decided how the food would taste and look, the waiter brought it to our table. No single person controlled the afternoon. Rather the experience came as a result of common decisions, but not all the people involved got equal recognition for their role. I was struck by Ray's (2010) observation about ways in which cooking work is aestheticized. How this explains my remarks about noticing the final product rather than the work that it creates. She argues that skill, beauty, emotion, and care can make hard work look natural and easy.At the table, I saw golden ringed calamari, the tartar sauce, lemon and clean plates, good service. I was not hidden to the work they did. They had to cook the food, organize themselves, work with oil, and clean, store food ingredients, and be polite to the customers. This was further emphasised in the Food and Gender lecture where it was demonstrated that the concept of foodwork can frequently be pushed aside by notions of care, authenticity, and good service. While the restaurant work is not as difficult as water collection is, that is a comparison that Kaur (2022) provides as a guideline. This idea was further advanced by Srinivas (2012) who demonstrated that convenience does not mean zero labour, it means labour elsewhere. The staff prepared and served us the meal and we enjoyed it. The waiters collected prepared food from a small service window. Same window used to send orders to the kitchen as well. However, dirty dishes did not return through the same window. The waiters carried them through the kitchen door and gave them to the dishwashing staff. This kept fresh meals separate from leftovers and used plates. The individuals involved in various aspects of the process had varying levels of control over them and were not equally recognised. Serving meals continued to be the primary concern. Workers typically were only seen when the order was late or when their service was praised. There was another question I had to ask myself about this: why did I take the food so easily when I normally didn't like it, and the meal required trust and much work to prepare it?

Why I don't like fish, I said earlier. My girlfriend does not have fish obsession but she appreciates well-cooked fish, unlike me, who preferred boneless fish. She didn't like soup and we didn't have the same tolerances for spice. I learned from the discussion from Meyer-Rochow (2009) that food avoidance doesn't have to be a formal taboo. Sometimes it comes as a result of repeated personal experiences. Because despite not being based on a rule, I still had a doubt, which was real. The recipe for my willingness to eat the calamari was a trust in my girlfriend, confidence in the restaurant, presentation, social interaction, and environment of the restaurant, not just one. I also had a few of the green chillies, which I am not a much fan of spicy food. It played a playful part, I wanted to impress her. The dish was influenced by the language. The word ‘calamari' was significant. Most customers are aware of the name of the product, which is squid, but the manager said that the name “fried squid” would not impact the choice of product. Research suggests that foreign or ethnic menu language can make food appear authentic and valuable. Still, this does not prove that customers order “calamari” more often than “squid” (Kim & Baker, 2017). But in Dhaka,scenario is now different. Tartar-like sauce is already common at low cost fish-and-chips stalls where dory is served, thus the same language means both street food or posh dining, depending on the establishment, cost and presentation. As discovered by Mukherjee (2014) in his research on global halal, global consumers often rely on institutions and others for making their halal choices. I didn't inquire if it is certified as halal or ask, neither I did see it on the menu. I took the words of the restaurant regarding the food at face value and forgot to ask myself where the calamari came from and how it got to my plate.

The manager had told me that the seafood vendors from Bangladesh had imported the squid. The restaurant received it frozen, stored it, and prepared it only after a customer placed an order (restaurant manager, personal communication, May 18, 2026). The distinction between the "inside" and "outside" meanings of food, in the words of Srinivas (2012), provided me with a way to grasp the seeming paradox of "fresh calamari" and imported frozen squid. As a customer, “freshness” to us was a clean flavor, no sour smell, crispy exterior and the calamari was cooked after we placed our order. Many people and systems helped bring the dish to our table. These included importers, suppliers, freezers, kitchen tools, menus, and restaurant practices from around the world. Frozen storage can preserve seafood without necessarily making it unsafe, but it may alter its texture and capacity to retain water, meaning that frozen seafood is not identical to seafood that has never been frozen (Gokoglu et al., 2018). Customers usually cannot verify

where restaurant food comes from. As a result, they depend on restaurant reputation, origin information, labels, and trusted sellers (Wu et al., 2021). A further question arose: was the dish completely foreign to the local custom or did it adapt to the local expectations? The presentation was international, perhaps representing a local influence, the green chillies. The manager, however, stated that it was the preparation that the chefs worked out, and that the head chef determined how the dishes were to be presented. He did not confirm that the restaurant added "green chilli" for the Bengali customers. So, I consider localization as my interpretation and not a fact. I cannot confirm it happened here, but Huang et al. (2024) state that it is possible to adapt. In any case, the chilli could be a reflection of the local taste, the chef's personal taste or a general garnishing practice. Celik's (2017) explanation of urban separation from food sources helped clarify why the further I followed the calamari in its travels, the more I knew nothing about it. The fun we had was owed to a lot of people and systems. Not every one of them got it equally.

The dinner had been good for us, but not for all those who had helped make it possible. My girlfriend and I were comforted, given some privacy, a new experience, courteous service, and a special meal. The price of fried calamari is Tk 525 with service charge. We went for a cheap cola though, not one of the house specials. We prioritized comfort after being drenched in sweat from the sun.. To us the price seemed reasonable due to the air-conditioning, location, atmosphere, food presentation and the service. Ryu et al. (2012) has helped to clarify why it was worth our while to visit this restaurant. But let's say that we should view the meal as being worth that cost, while many others may not be able to afford it. The restaurant made a profit and was able to attract customers. Suppliers got business and the restaurant itself created employment. But the burden of making the experience of a calm worker was on a physical and emotional level. I appreciate the insight that Ray's (2010) discussion provided me with as to why that effort was so much like an invisible one at the meal. If workers can show their labour in beautiful and pleasant manner, the consumer can eat without thinking about their working condition. As customers rarely left calamari unfinished and pre-preparing food after receiving orders decreased the waste, Manager said. The observations referred to, however, were restricted to observation of prepared food and plate waste. There is still a possibility of waste resulting from storage, packaging, cooking oil, transportation and imported cold chain. As taught by Tscharntke et al.

(2012), it is not possible to evaluate a food system solely on its food production efficiency . Waste, environmental support and people's access to food should also be taken into account as well as distribution. Until I have the proper facts I can't figure out the environmental impact of our meal without making it up. It was fair in a very limited way, as we were aware that we were paying for enjoyable food and good service. Yet, I was not able to evaluate its overall fairness due to the lack of information regarding the working conditions, risk of sourcing and environmental impact.

The menu could read “Imported frozen squid, fresh to the table after ordering” and the restaurant might educate all their employees on what it means every time. The waiter explained that it was fresh and the manager later explained that the squid was imported and then frozen. The waiter's statement can be true and the manager's statement can be true. Some customers however, might get confused as many think “fresh” means the product has never been frozen. Mukherjee's (2014) discussion reminded me that customers often believe rumors they cannot prove. The political-economy lens also influenced my understanding of transparency in this course. I didn't just see it as information, I saw it as making the institutional work behind the meal visible. Customers' reaction is going to be the major problem. While imported seafood sometimes needs a controlled cold chain, some people might think of frozen food as poor quality, and avoid it. Improved transparency could lead to better customer trust, and, at the same time, but it could also reduce the dish’s high-end image and sales. Clear words may offer an understanding of how a fresh cuisine of the frozen squid can be prepared after an order without compromising the taste, atmosphere, and convenience. It would also help prevent staff from providing explanations that seem contradictory. That is why I consider this slight suggestion more realistic. I cannot argue that restaurants should source everything locally. I also cannot demand complete environmental reporting because I have limited evidence.

This encounter no longer feels like just my experience. I went into Rustic Eatery looking to escape from a hot day, spend some time with someone I care about. I now realize that the evening was based on relationships, labor, institutions, global supply chains and unequal opportunities which were not always obvious to me then. It did not last in my mind because the

calamari was something extraordinary, but because I had taken some of the 'normal life' for granted. Every part of the evening depended on something I had initially overlooked. Institutions were the basis of trust. Comfort was based upon work. My food was based on relationships, and presentation. Even for the basic calamari appetizer, the systems were extensive beyond our table. I picked the restaurant and evaluated its quality, and my girlfriend suggested the type of food, and she paid. The chef did the preparation, staff did our experience and suppliers provided the squid. This activity was not led by ‘just’ one person. Different decisions shaped the evening, but people did not value them equally. The dish also had some contradictions. It came from another country but felt local. It was frozen, but we enjoyed it as fresh. It looked expensive, but it still had to fit our budget. The contradictions show how the restaurant experience is constructed out of various meanings, expectations and systems. I could not have been a neutral observer since I was looking for romance, comfort, novelty, and value that filtered out what I saw and paid no attention to. I cannot claim that one meal represents Bangladesh. It does, however, indicate a larger trend pattern in the current urban Bangladesh that the global food is transformed into the local food through a process of trust, service, and gradual cultural adaptation. After paying the bill, most restaurant meals are gone from anyone’s mind. This one never did. In retrospect, now I don't just see fried calamari from the photo! This simple plate brings together trust, care, hidden labour, unequal opportunities, and global systems.

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